Atkinson Spanish Immersion: Facts for Our Meeting with PPS

Atkinson Dual Language Immersion (DLI) families · PTA meeting with Director Stephanie Engleman · October 2026

Both PPS rightsizing scenarios (A and B) move Atkinson's K-5 Spanish immersion program 2.4 miles east to Lent, at the edge of the district. Creston's neighborhood students would move into Atkinson. **Our main concern: losing a popular, central Southeast program.**

1. ATKINSON IMMERSION IS IN DEMAND

In the 2026-27 kindergarten lottery, Atkinson had the **longest waitlist of any PPS immersion program** and the most applications of any Spanish program (only Richmond's Japanese program had more). Over 5 years it averaged about **5 applications for every seat** offered (121 vs 24).

2026-27 kindergarten	Applied	Offered	Waitlisted
Atkinson	125	25	47
Native & heritage	42	19	14
Lent (for comparison)	49	24	13

Rigler and Lent enroll most children without the lottery, so their demand does not show here. Native and heritage = Spanish-speaking children. The waitlist alone could fill much of a second balanced class. A family can be on several waitlists, so waitlist places are not all separate children.

2. CENTRAL SITE VS EDGE SITE

- Atkinson is **1.8 miles** from the district edge. Lent is **0.3 miles** from it.
- Two in three Atkinson immersion students (**118 of 178**) already come from outside Atkinson's neighborhood.
- Their trip to school would grow about **1 mile** on average (estimate from PPS home-neighborhood data).
- Across PPS, the share of Spanish-speaking children (ages 5-17) living within 1 mile of a Spanish immersion school drops from about **52% to 36%** under either scenario.

3. WHO MOVES, AND WHAT CHANGES AT ATKINSON

Atkinson is an example of a well-resourced school that is currently serving **21% multilingual learners** and **44% historically underserved learners** *(40% and 71% in its immersion program). Why fix something that's not broken? Especially when the consequences run contrary to the stated goals of rightsizing?*

Atkinson	Immersion program	Whole school today	Whole school after move
Multilingual learners	40%	21%	7%
Historically underserved	71%	44%	21%
Poverty	not published	32%	23%

Today = October 2025. "After move" = PPS's projection in its Atkinson guide. Historically underserved = PPS's race-based group (Latino, Black, Native American, Pacific Islander; excludes Asian and white). Poverty = direct certification, published for whole schools only.

- Nine in ten of Atkinson's multilingual learners (**72 of 78**) are in the immersion program. The program is **70% Latino**; the neighborhood program is 8% Latino and 76% white.
- Racial separation among Southeast schools (Atkinson, Lent, Creston) rises: Latino-white dissimilarity index **0.35 → 0.58** (0 = evenly mixed, 1 = fully separate).
- Lent's school grounds are about **120 feet from I-205**. Atkinson is 1.5 miles from the nearest freeway.

4. WHAT HAPPENED LAST TIME: BRIDGER → LENT (2023)

- Lent now enrolls **31% fewer** immersion kindergartners than Bridger and Lent did together before the move. The district fell 14% over the same period.
- PPS's 2023 plan projected 527 students at Lent for 2025-26. Lent has **256**, in a building for about 798 (32% full).
- PPS's new guides expect only about **4 in 5** Atkinson immersion students to follow the program to Lent.

5. OUR CONCERNS ABOUT SCENARIOS A AND B

- **Equity:** Furthers segregation as an unintended consequence; increases vulnerability of an already frightened community; removes choice for ESL students; worsens environmental injustice.
- **Enrollment:** Demand could fill a second DLI kindergarten class, drawing families from across the city; NH DLI families overwhelmingly say they won't transfer to Lent; Lent remains under-enrolled despite PPS's projections.
- **Community:** A diverse school community is an asset to all students; Atkinson's central Southeast location makes it reachable for native and heritage families from outside the neighborhood; walking and biking are a priority for Atkinson families.
- **Process:** Is four weeks really enough time to address the concerns of thousands of parents? Incomplete transition plans are unacceptable.

6. QUESTIONS FOR DIRECTOR ENGLEMAN

1. After the Bridger move, Lent lost families beyond the district trend. What will PPS do differently to keep Atkinson families?
2. Every projection for Lent has been too high (527 planned, 256 actual). Why is the new 400+ projection more reliable?
3. Will PPS provide bus service from the Atkinson area to Lent? Busing plans so far are shown only for North Portland.
4. Has PPS measured air quality at Lent, next to I-205? What filtration or other protections are planned?
5. Can current Atkinson immersion students and their younger siblings finish at Atkinson? What is the timeline?
6. PPS's guide says Lent with Atkinson's program meets the size goal but not the space goal. What does that mean?
7. Did PPS study keeping a central Southeast Spanish immersion site?

7. WHAT WE ASK

- Pause the process to allow deep engagement with PPS families and revision of the proposals.
- Move Creston to Glencoe (suggested at a recent district meeting).

Sources: PPS 2026-27 Kindergarten Lottery Results and 2022-23 to 2026-27 lottery reports; PPS School Profiles dashboard (2025); PPS Enrollment Summary by Race and Ethnicity and Language Immersion Track Profiles (Oct 2025); PPS rightsizing school guides for Atkinson and Lent (Oct 8, 2026); PPS Enrollment by Neighborhood of Residence; PSU enrollment forecasts; PPS Southeast Guiding Coalition equity audit; U.S. Census ACS (C16001/B16007); OpenStreetMap. Analysis: pps-dli-explorer.netlify.app (independent; builds on pps-explorer by Jason Brown and ppsdata.info). Distances and the 1-mile trip increase are estimates; see the site's Methods page.